

tracted.
sources deny that
caused a spat between
and the Government.
commitment was given,
the foreign office that
sted that the DG ISI's
at this point in time in

APP PHOTO/FAROOQ NAEEM



(CENTRE) WITH NAWAZ
ND FROM LEFT), FAZL-UR-
(SECOND FROM RIGHT),
MARY SHUJAAT HUSSAIN
) AT AN ALL-PARTY MEET

ed the problem of his
community. This factor
change in stance,"
r military source.
initial fumbles seem to
settled down into more
decision-making. The
army chief and prime
ve been holding late
ngs where daily brief-
iven and notes ex-
d coordinated. It was
at led to the call for
es conference on na-

tional security where politicians
of all hues extended unqualified
support to the Government. But
in practical terms, nationalist
rhetoric does not materially
change the situation much.
Sources close to Zardari say that
the Mumbai attack has created a
nightmare scenario for his
Government. "We can sense the
pressure mount on Pakistan from
all sides," said a Zardari aide.

This pressure stems from a
feeling that the hawks in the US
administration might seize this
opportunity to build a case for
de-nuclearising Pakistan. The
sequence of this fear is that India
might coordinate aerial strikes
with the US on terror targets in
urban areas, forcing Pakistan to
rattle its nuclear saber. "That is
the point where the US would in-
voke the right of pre-emptive
strike against Pakistan's nuclear
installations, extending NATO
support to India. Pakistan could
be presented with the option of
either facing a three-dimen-
sional nuclear strike or rolling
back its nuclear programme,"
says a senior military official.
That might sound far-fetched,
but it is one measure of how taut
nerves are in Islamabad.

It is a result of this informal
but regular coordination that
Zardari has taken a stand on the
list of 20 persons wanted by India
that is consistent with Pakistan's
standard position: no evidence,
no processing the request. This
puts Zardari on a tightrope: to be
seen as cooperating with India
but sticking to his stance in the
domestic arena.

by Syed Talat Hussain in Islamabad

action against states that violate it. Bilaterally it
would engage countries like the US, the UK and
Saudi Arabia that hold the strategic levers on
Pakistan to take steps to dismantle its terror in-
frastructure. As a pressure point, India is eyeing
the \$7.6-billion bailout package the IMF an-
nounced recently for Pakistan to tide over its
economic crisis. If Europe and other countries
agree to hold back disbursements, Pakistan
would be forced to act or face financial collapse.

Experts know that India's options to act
against Pakistan are limited. Pakistan
knows that too and its reaction so far is true to
form: steadfastly deny Pakistani links while
making empty promises to cooperate and wait
for the incident to recede from world attention.
Indian strategists have watched with mounting
frustration as Pakistan has been successfully al-
lowed to get away with a policy what G.
Parthasarathy, former high commissioner to
Pakistan, calls "low in risk but high in gain". An
example is the blast at the Indian Embassy in
Kabul this August that killed four Indians, an act
of terrorism that even the US intelligence agen-
cies saw a Pakistan hand in and yet the incident
is all but forgotten. K.C. Singh, former MEA sec-
retary who headed the Joint Terror Mechanism,
terms the approach "an eyewash" and says "no
substantial progress was made".

Pakistan's bold approach has come after it
has noticed India's impotence to launch an all-
out war against it ever since it got some sort of
nuclear parity with India. In the gravest of provo-
cation during the Kargil War in 1999, India did
not exercise its option of striking Pakistan be-
yond the Kashmir border, the first time in the
four wars it has fought with its neighbour. The
then government headed by A.B. Vajpayee did
not want the war to escalate into an all-out con-
flict that could have a nuclear dimension.

Then after the 2001 Parliament attack, India
broke off diplomatic relations and amassed its
troops on Pakistan's border. But while there
were some incremental gains from Operation
Parakram, it was evident that India was hesitant
to launch a military strike even under the
gravest of provocation. After a costly nine-month

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